

Safety for the bluecoats beckoned on the high ground of Cemetery Hill, which was occupied by reserves that Howard had wisely left there. Now those forces would serve as protection against the expected Confederate assault as the sun began to sink lower in the sky. But that assault never came. Lee knew that the rest of the Union army was on its way and that now was the time to strike the final blow. He turned to Ewell and ordered him to attack the heights "if practicable." Ewell, aware of his troops' exhaustion and worried by reports of Federals to his left, did not find an attack practicable. Most of the defeated Union Eleventh and First Corps escaped to Cemetery Hill where, shaken and hurt, they regrouped.

The second day begins

General George G. Meade, commander of the Army of the Potomac, rode up before midnight. Conferring with Second Corps commander, Lieutenant General Winfield S. Hancock, he inspected the positions, and deemed them secure. By the early morning of July 2, three more Union corps had joined their comrades on Cemetery Hill.

Frustrated by the hollow victory of the previous day, Lee met his generals to consider options. Rejecting a proposal from Lieutenant General James Longstreet to move around the enemy and reposition between them and Washington, Lee decided on a double envelopment. Longstreet's First Corps would attack the Union southern (left) flank with two divisions and a third from Hill's corps, while Ewell would try to deceive the enemy with a show of force against Cemetery and Culp's hills.

Due to a failure in communications on Lee's part, Longstreet was slow in sending forward his two divisions, commanded by generals Lafayette McLaws and John Bell Hood. Federal signalers on Little Round Top at the end of the Northern line spotted their initial movements. Longstreet's infantry lost valuable time as it doubled back to take an unobserved route. By the time McLaws and Hood charged forward about 4 p.m., General Daniel Sickles' Union Third Corps had advanced to the Emmitsburg Road Ridge and blocked